

in online non-alcoholic and low-alcoholic beverage sales last year.

While India is still a nascent market, it is only likely to grow. There is a whole class of enthusiasts that is embracing non-alcoholic beverages because they are low on calories, considered somewhat healthier and, most importantly, claim to not compromise on taste. "Our customers vary from people who don't drink at all to those who drink occasionally to those who cannot drink for whatever reason," says Aneesh Bhasin, Co-founder of Mumbai-based Svami, a pioneer in the Indian craft tonic water space that launched three ready-to-drink non-alcoholic cocktails—G&T, Pink Gin & Tonic and Rum & Cola—last year. "If someone does not want to drink alcohol, she should have more tasty and complex drinking options available." Svami's beverages, which were launched after a year of R&D to get the taste just right, are already contributing 20-25 per cent to its revenues. While the G&T has classic botanicals like juniper, its non-alcoholic Rum & Cola is flavoured with vanilla, caramel and cinnamon, and has only 56 calories.

Delhi-based craft beer brand Kati Patang also launched its range of non-alcoholic beverages called NOT last year. Available in three flavours—NOT G&T, NOT Cosmopolitan and NOT Old Fashioned—these imitate the taste of the popular cocktails, minus the alcohol and the calories. "Our NOT Old Fashioned brings alive a not-usual experience, with over 35 spices, to give you the complex flavour and experience of the classic cocktail with no alcohol and lower calories," says Lata Upadhyay, Co-founder and Chief Brand Officer of Kati Patang. The NOT Old Fashioned, which has oaky notes of bourbon whisky, zero-alcohol aromatic bitters, and the fine finish of vanilla and nutty flavours, has only 19 kcal per 100 ml.

Upadhyay says the company did not anticipate the demand and has



1. Budweiser 0.0 is priced at ₹80 for a 330-ml can and is available at leading e-commerce channels

2. Svami undertook R&D for nearly a year to perfect the taste of its non-alcoholic cocktails

run out of stocks. The next production cycle starts in mid-June and stocks will be replenished by July.

Sober Gin is the latest entrant in the market. This Goa-based gin has zero carbs, zero sugar, zero alcohol and only five calories. It is infused with juniper berries, ashwagandha and tulsi, which is supposed to boost immunity. Priced at ₹1,499, it can be purchased from the website. On its website, its Founder Vansh Pahuja says that the pandemic was a turning point for Sober. "The government banned all liquor stores, and all bars and restaurants were shut down. So, what do people drink now when they are not drinking? Now almost everyone is not drinking... Can anything replicate the same experience or ritual?" Pahuja says that's how Sober, India's first non-alcohol-



ic distilled spirit, came into being.

Ganesh Iyer, Managing Partner for Indian Subcontinent at Zero Percent Shop, a division of privately owned Finnish company Third Culture Group, says it's all about mindful consumption. "Globally, especially post the pandemic, people are now more conscious of their health and what they are consuming. Low on calories, low on sugar is gaining prominence. Plus, the 18-24-year-olds are hardly drinking alcohol."

Zero Percent only stocks craft products that use botanicals and natural ingredients with no emulsifiers or preservatives. Some of the products include Naughty Sparkling Chardonnay made from grapes of southern Spain. With only 2.9 gm of sugar per 100 ml, it has just 14 calories per glass. A bottle costs ₹1,750. Coast from Belgium is an alcohol-free craft beer with citrus and tropical fruit flavours, priced at ₹250 for a can. It has only 33 calories. There is also GinISH from Denmark made from natural botanicals such as juniper berries, coriander seeds and chilli, and tastes like gin. It is priced at ₹1,750 for a bottle.

Zero-alcohol beer is likely to be the next big thing globally. According to insightSLICE, a US-based global market research provider, the global non-alcoholic beer market size was estimated to be \$9.6 bil-